

Turning Brownfields Green

With the first hints of spring in the air, parents across the nation pack up the kids and head to America's parks. Whether it's a friendly game of Little League baseball at the local diamond in suburban Orlando, a hike through rugged terrain on a quiet county trail system in Sauk County, Wisconsin or a stroll along San Antonio's River Walk, Americans use the nation's public recreational spaces in growing numbers each year. Across the country, new parks, trails, stadiums, riverfront paths and heritage centers are springing up on brownfield sites in the heart of city centers. These projects rehabilitate large pieces of idle property, encourage the redevelopment of adjacent land and often introduce sorely needed greenspace into congested urban centers. Through the combined efforts of local governments, federal grant money, neighborhood groups and property owners, a variety of enterprising and creative recreational projects are on the drawing board or under construction in America's cities and small towns.

Photo by Joe Bly



Central Park, New York City

The economics of park development on brownfields is as varied as the facilities themselves. In some cases parks are the simplest way to deal with a site—cap it, landscape it, and put some equipment on it. In other cases the facilities are developed as a way to improve a particular site—changing a large industrial property to residential use works better if there is usable and inviting greenspace close to the new housing. Recreational development can also be the best use of a property—in the case of Baltimore, there really was no other use for the waterfront except for entertainment and recreation. In still other cases, such as San Francisco's Presidio Army base, the land was already used as a park and doing anything else with it would be destructive and would meet with strong public opposition.

The History of Parks

The earliest European settlements in North America allotted land as open space for public use. The Spanish settlements of Florida were built around a central plaza. French villages along the Mississippi River included open public space at the shore. The colonial British set aside "commons" in their settlements. This land was reserved for the Puritan's meetinghouse and graveyard. As the religious affiliations of New Englanders diversified in the early 1800s churches were no longer built in the center of town and the Common became an open public "green".

American city parks grew not from religious necessity or civic pride, but rather from a growing fear of rapid industrialization and urbanization. Drawing on the manicured lawns and gardens of the English country estate and the tranquility and "natural settings" of cemeteries on the outskirts of American towns and cities, the new parks were designed to be places of escape for the middle class; peaceful, rural havens from the bustle, grime and class tensions of urban life. Designers intended the parks to moralize and "Americanize" immigrants. As a quiet and idyllic place, planners believed the urban park would be an uplifting experience and remove workers from their ethnic ghettos and tavern for a time.

The most famous of these new urban parks was New York City's Central Park, which opened in 1858. Designed by Frederick Law Olmsted and Calvert Vaux, Central Park was several parks rolled into one. Olmsted and Vaux left much of the rocky, wild northern section of the park as they found it, adding only vegetation. The southern half of the park was dotted with groves, boating ponds and meadows interspersed with walkways, horse paths and carriageways. Through careful grading and placement of bridges, city streets intersecting the park were hidden from view where they intersected with the park paths.

While Olmsted designed a park devoid of monuments and other "city" structures, urban politics intervened. City bosses viewed the park as a source of patronage jobs and construction projects. Over the years, Central Park became the home to museums, aquariums, zoos and observatories. Furthermore, New York's working classes wanted more than bridle paths and meadow vistas. In response, playgrounds became part of Central Park.

The Changing Role of Parks

For the next fifty years, Olmsted's ideal Central Park stood as a model for urban parks systems throughout the nation, but not without conflict. Working-class Americans challenged the idea of the park as a pastoral haven. These Americans wanted to enjoy the outdoors at athletic fields, playgrounds and picnic groves to escape the overcrowded conditions of their neighborhoods and homes. Pressure from the park's users at the ballot box led to design changes by the early 1900s.



An architectural rendering of the Baltimore harbor redevelopment.

Progressive Era politicians and activists concerned with alleviating the harsh conditions in America's cities brought about by rapid industrialization also played an important role in the growth of urban parks. For these reformers, new playgrounds and athletic fields improved both the moral and physical health and welfare of impoverished urban families. City parks were increasingly designed with organized activities in mind and baseball diamonds and field houses containing gymnasiums and club rooms became commonplace.

The conservation and preservation of open greenspace in the country as well as the city was a lasting legacy of the Progressive Era. John Muir, the founder of the modern environmental movement pushed for the passage of the Yosemite Act of 1890 that created the nation's first nature preserve and publicized Muir's concern with the "overcivilization" of America. President Theodore Roosevelt, an avid outdoorsman, created the U.S. Forest Service in 1905 and the National Park Service in 1916.

A number of trends over the last forty years has brought urban recreational space and park redevelopment to the forefront of urban planning. Americans' growing interest in health and outdoor activities over the last thirty years has led to a dramatic increase in the number of running and walking trails across America.

Parks on Brownfields

Small towns as well as big cities benefit from this enthusiasm for fitness as well as growing concern for land reuse. In the early 1970s, using a small federal grant, Lilburn, Georgia, built a park complete with a fitness track, athletic field, playground and restrooms on a former landfill. Today, thousands of Lilburn residents use the park each week.

Lately, the recent renaissance of the nation's city centers has contributed to both the refurbishment of existing parks and recreational facilities and exciting new opportunities for urban planners and developers to refurbish brownfields and urban waterways for new residential, commercial and recreational uses.

A growing interest in American history via "cultural parks" and "heritage centers" has also helped spur extensive redevelopment plans in many metropolitan areas. The idea behind these parks or centers is that city centers can and should be sites for historical and architectural preservation, cultural and educational opportunities as well as economic development and revitalization. Cities across the nation are working to become more tourist-friendly with mapped historical walks, craft and arts festivals and other urban interactive experiences.

One of the most ambitious projects that combines recreational and commercial redevelopment can be found in Lowell, Massachusetts. The birthplace of America's industrial revolution in the early 1800s, Lowell was hit by hard times in the recessions and plant closings of the 1970s. A combination of state, federal and private funding made this

tremendous turnaround possible. In 1975, the Commonwealth of Massachusetts began the Heritage State Park program and committed \$14 million to the refurbishment of the banks of the Merrimack River and related canals. Three years later the U.S. Congress enacted legislation to create the Lowell National Historical Park. Forty million dollars was set aside to develop an interactive historical center featuring 19th-century buildings and over five miles of canals. Lowell is also the home to two new stadiums, Tsongas Arena and LeLacheur Stadium, both built on abandoned industrial sites. To date more than \$350 million of private and public funds have been spent in historic preservation, commercial and industrial development, rehabilitation, and educational, recreational and cultural projects in Lowell. Located 25 miles northwest of Boston, today Lowell, (pop. 100,000) attracts more than 600,000 tourists a year.

Baltimore Turnsto Recreation

Over thirty years ago, business leaders in Baltimore responded to the pressure of suburban sprawl with a plan to redevelop the city's downtown district. According to Laurie Schwartz, Deputy Mayor for Economic Development, the city has included the waterfront in its redevelopment plans for the last twenty years. Today, Baltimore's Inner Harbor is both a recreational and business destination. Thirty years ago Baltimore's waterfront consisted mostly of abandoned piers and a "not-so-working waterfront," said Schwartz. Downtown business leaders and city officials envisioned a waterfront set aside for public open space and recreational activities. Over the course of twenty years the City of Baltimore purchased all the land in the Inner Harbor area and set it aside for redevelopment. Today, two museums anchor the Inner Harbor as an important tourist attraction—the Maryland Science Center sits on the South and the National Aquarium on the North of the Harbor.

The Inner Harbor is also home to Harbor Place, a "festival marketplace" development by the Rouse Company which includes retail and food establishments. The Power Plant, a retail space housed in a former electric power plant is home to a number of national chains including the Hard Rock Café, Gold's Gym, the ESPNZone and a Barnes & Noble bookstore. The city of Baltimore was hard hit by the recession of the early 1990s but has recovered over the last four years and attracted new industries to the city, particularly to the Inner Harbor and its adjoining neighborhoods.

Struever Bros., Eccles & Rouse, a redevelopment construction firm has been at the forefront of renovating old warehouse buildings to attract new companies to the city. According to Schwartz, the company has helped pave the way for a recent boom in high technology firms locating in Baltimore. Retail and new industries are not the only attractions fueling the growth of Baltimore's Inner Harbor and its neighbors. Baltimore's age and its important role in American history have made it an obvious choice for heritage tourism. The city's place as an important urban center in the colonial era, the headway of the National Road, America's first roadway built in the early 1800s and as a spot on the Underground Railroad make Baltimore an attractive historical destination.

On the Waterfrontin Kansas City

Kansas City, Missouri has big plans for its own riverfront development and heritage project. According to Andrew Bracker, Brownfields Coordinator for Kansas City, Missouri and Kansas City, Kansas, the Missouri side has extensive plans for the Riverfront Heritage Trails Project, a series of walkways and bike paths connecting the urban waterfront with several downtown districts, a residential neighborhood, a wetlands, a central industrial district and an urban archeological park. Central to this project will be Riverfront Park, a 100-acre parcel, formerly a manufactured gas plant site, of which 60 acres could be developed into mixed-use office, commercial, residential and recreational space including a freshwater aquarium.

This property offers excellent views of the river and city skyline and access to River Market, a farmers market center and the loft district, part of Kansas City's eclectic downtown district. The Riverfront Heritage Project is an ambitious and progressive one on a number of levels. It will make the city more pedestrian-accessible, link communities formerly segregated by highway development, as well as railroad tracks, and highlight the area's rich historical and ecological resources. This project will not only affect the land currently slated for redevelopment but will affect surrounding properties. As Bracker points out, "There are nine brownfield sites that border or are very close to this proposed trail system. This trail will be an important amenity to the redevelopment of these properties." The anticipated costs of the entire project run between \$300-500 million which will be covered by state and federal grants as well as funds raised by the nonprofit KC Rivertrails, Inc.

Enhancing Existing Parks

The City of Pittsburgh is currently redeveloping a 238-acre brownfield for residential and recreational use. The Nine Mile Run project, named for a stream noted by Frederick Law Olmsted for its beauty and its waste water problems in 1910, will result in 713 units of market rate housing and the addition of 100 acres of land to Frick Park, one of the city's largest parks. Purchased in the 1920s by the Duquesne Slag Company, the western bank of the stream was used as a dump for the steel smelting byproduct, slag. In 1995, the city purchased the site for \$3.8 million for redevelopment.

According to Marc Knezevich, Senior Project Development Specialist with the Urban Redevelopment Authority of Pittsburgh, "Summerset at Frick Park," the residential development, will follow the "new urbanism" model of a mix of single family homes, townhouses and rental apartments with a system of alleys and sidewalks. To prepare the site, dirt will be mixed with the slag and the site will be capped with two feet of dirt. (The Pennsylvania Department of Environmental Protection follows use-based standards for brownfield cleanup.) According to Joan Blaustein, manager of special projects for the Pittsburgh Department of City Planning, the water and stream bank remediation of the 100-acre addition to Frick Park should begin in early 2001 after the property is deeded to the City of Pittsburgh. The project is expected to take two years.

In San Francisco a former administrative military base has found new life as a residential, business and recreational space. The Presidio, a nearly 1,500 acre parcel of land situated at the foot of the Golden Gate Bridge was transferred to the National Park Service in 1994. The Presidio Trust, an independent federal agency oversees the property which by law must become economically independent by 2013.

According to Martha Walters, Senior Environmental Project Manager for the San Francisco Redevelopment Agency, the Trust is currently revising its General Management Plan. The Trust is focusing its energies on finding a viable commercial tenant for the Letterman Hospital Complex, a 23-acre parcel in the Presidio. The Trust and George Lucas of Lucasfilm are in ongoing exclusive negotiations for the site. Lucasfilm hopes to develop a next-generation facility for Industrial Light & Magic, THX Group, his film company.

The base was unique in that civilians have always had access to large parts of the property, using its roads as thoroughways to other parts of the city and its beaches for relaxation. Environmentally, the property did not require a tremendous amount of cleanup. According to Walters, the Army gave the Trust \$100 million to defray the costs. Cleanup focused mainly on aircraft and vehicle maintenance areas, two gas stations and an underground fuel line system.

The former Army apartments and houses are managed by John Stewart Housing Management and are leased at market rates. Former administrative buildings house startup internet companies and the Old Letterman Hospital was rehabbed for the Thoreau Center—an umbrella group for non-profit organizations. The Presidio is also home to over twenty acres of restored wetlands and other beachfront and open spaces available for public recreational use. Plans for the restoration of Crissy Field, an airfield, and the creation of an environmental center are underway.

Innovations in Reuse

Introducing children to new sports is also spurring the redevelopment of brownfields. Across the country dormant landfills are being slated for golf courses. According to Richard Bowers, Vice President of Community Affairs for the PGA Tour, the First Tee Program, a program working to build affordable and accessible golf facilities for children, has projects on the drawing board or underway in half a dozen cities. The program works with local governments to find appropriate sites within the city limits. First Tee brings approximately \$300,000 worth of direct grants, including discounts in equipment. The program also works with Audubon International to create course rough areas with indigenous plant life. Projects currently underway in Richmond, Virginia, Fort Worth, Texas and Hammond, Indiana are all being built on former landfills.

One of the most successful recreational reuses of brownfields are "rail trails," multi-purpose public paths created from abandoned railroad corridors. In some cases trails are built on dormant rails through "railbanking," a voluntary agreement between a railroad company and a trail agency, where the long-term possibility of returned rail service exists. Found in rural, urban and suburban areas, these trails are popular for walking, jogging, biking, cross-county skiing and horseback riding. Often they link neighborhoods and workplaces, or even small towns. They showcase local wildlife, architecture and historical sites.

Rail-trails have positively affected local economies. The Rails-to-Trails Conservancy estimates that trail users have generated as much as \$1.25 million annually for the towns

through which a trail passes. A study of one of the earliest trails, the 32-mile Elroy-Sparta State Park Trail in Wisconsin, showed that local peak-season motel rooms are booked up to a full year in advance and that the average visitor to the trail travels 228 miles to experience it. Across the nation, there are over 10,000 miles of public rail trails and in 1999, these trails were used more than 100 million times. In cities and small towns throughout America the opportunities for the redevelopment of brownfields for recreational use are growing.

A new Progressive Era may be dawning; one that combines the restoration of brownfields with new thinking about recreation, greenspace and local history. Cooperation among local governments, private property owners and federal and state funding programs can lead to exciting new opportunities to create parks, trails and even sports facilities that highlight a region's natural and historical assets while increasing the livability of communities, and providing economical end-uses of brownfields.

Liesl Orenic is a professor of history in Chicago